JUST A WAVE AWAY

CONTACTLESS IS THE NEW BUZZWORD WITH RETAILERS GLOBALLY ADOPTING THIS FASTER AND SAFER MODE FOR TRANSACTIONS

By **M.G. ARUN**



It has been two years since Kishore Rajan, 45, an executive with an MNC in Mumbai, keyed in his debit card PIN into any point-of-sale (POS) machine at a shopping outlet or a petrol pump. Instead, he has enabled the tap-and-go facility, which allows the card to emit short-range electromagnetic waves containing its information that the POS machine captures bypassing any physical contact. "I found it most useful during the Covid-19 pandemic," says Rajan, "as I was quite concerned about contracting the virus from touching a possibly contaminated machine surface." Now, the same facility—known variously as contactless, touch-free or proximity payments—makes transactions a lot faster, more secure and convenient.

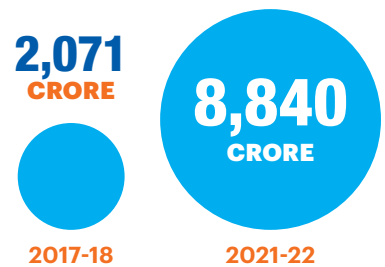
WHY IT IS A GAME CHANGER

A contactless payment—made using a chip-enabled bank card or a digital wallet app on a smartphone—is a wireless transaction and provides enhanced security since the buyer's financial details stay protected rather than being directly shared with the merchant.

The total number of digital transactions in India—including the Unified Payments Interface (BHIM-UPI), Immediate Payment Service (IMPS) and National Electronic Toll Collection (NETC)—quadrupled between 2017-18 and 2021-22. This comes as no surprise as ours is a country with one of the world's largest young (and tech-savvy) populations and a rising base of internet users. From 662 million in 2020, the number of internet users in India is expected to surpass the 900-million milestone by 2025, according to the Internet and Mo-

ON THE RISE

In India, digital transactions quadrupled in four years



Source: GoI